

Islamic influence on Western philosophy



The Greek mathematical, scientific and philosophical knowledge that enriched Islamic culture was virtually unknown in Europe until the 11th century.

Islamic philosophy grew largely from the Greek tradition, with philosophers such as Averroes and Avicenna adding their own commentaries to the ideas of Plato and Aristotle. Many of these philosophers worked in the universities and libraries of the major Islamic cities, notably the Bayt al-Hikma or 'House of Wisdom' in Baghdad, where ancient texts were preserved and translated. This was in contrast with Christian scholarship, which remained suspicious of what it saw as pagan philosophy. In the 11th

century, however, Christian conquests of Jerusalem, Sicily and some of Islamic Spain increased contact between the two cultures. European scholars gained access to the ancient texts and their Islamic commentaries, translating them into Latin. The new availability of classical ideas prompted a renewed interest in philosophy in Christian Europe, and the works of Aristotle in particular became the foundation of the scholastic movement (see [Scholasticism and dogma](#)). Just as importantly, Islamic scientific and mathematical ideas became available – although it took much longer for their influence to become noticeable.